

• PERSONALISED ROADMAP • STAGE 5 • \$10M+

The Manufacturer's PROFIT ROADMAP

You built something rare. Now protect its value and decide deliberately what it should become after you.

By **Bernard Powell**
Premier Business Academy · Hamilton, NZ



STAGE 5 DIAGNOSIS

**Where You Are The Honest Truth
You're doing \$10M+. Executive team.
Multi-site or multi-line. Real margins.
4–8× EBITDA multiplier is on the table.
Every decision from here is about
governance, succession, exit, and
legacy - not operations.**

WHAT THIS FEELS LIKE

You've earned the right to think long. What happens to this business in 10 years? 20? Do you sell? Hand it to the next generation? Use it as a platform for something bigger? None of these are operational questions. They're questions about who you are and what you're building for. They're the hardest questions, and they only have to be answered once - properly.

12 MONTHS FROM NOW

If nothing changes, the business keeps running but loses optionality. An unplanned health event, a founder conflict, a market shift - any one of these can destroy value you spent 20 years building. Governance and succession aren't about exit, they're about protecting what you've made.

4–8× EBITDA is the multiplier band available to well-governed, well-run NZ manufacturers at this scale. The gap between 4× and 8× is rarely about revenue - it's about governance, systems, leadership depth, and strategic narrative.

"The final act of building a great business is deciding - deliberately - what you want it to be after you're done with it."

— Bernard Powell

What you'll read next Production - SOPs and quality systems. Sales & Pricing - cost-per-unit and quote discipline. Cash Flow - Friday rhythm and forecasting. People - delegation and retention. Systems - documented process ownership. Marketing - referrals and lead consistency. Your Role - shifting from worker to owner.

AREA 1 OF 7

Production Multi-site capability. Next: automation and R&D discipline.

The operating model works across sites or lines. Lean is mature. The next frontier is automation investment and R&D as a discipline - not reactive improvements but a structured pipeline of 2–5 year bets that keep you ahead of offshore or scale competitors.

3–5% of revenue R&D spend at ~3–5% of revenue is typical of NZ manufacturers that sustain premium margins. Under-investing here is the slow, invisible killer of multiplier.

The Fix:

1. Create a formal capex / automation roadmap - 3-year horizon, owned by the COO.
2. Establish an R&D budget line as a % of revenue and defend it through cycles.
3. Benchmark your productivity ratios against international peers, not just local. The gap is often eye-opening.

"Most manufacturers at this scale underinvest in R&D because returns are slow. The ones who don't still exist in 15 years. The ones who do get acquired."

— Bernard Powell

Bernard's note The first SOP should be ugly. A phone video, a checklist, and one clear quality standard beat another month of explaining the job from scratch. Clean it up later - the real win is getting the process out of your head.

AREA 2 OF 7

Sales & Pricing Direct sales strong. Next: channels, partnerships, national accounts.

Direct sales work. But pure direct sales at this scale leaves growth on the table. National accounts, distribution partnerships, licensing, and joint ventures each open doors you can't walk through with a direct-sales team alone. Structured right, channel revenue carries less owner risk and scales faster than hiring more reps.

20–40% revenue lift Channel and partnership revenue often adds 20–40% on top of a strong direct- sales base - at comparable or better margins once overhead is factored in.

The Fix:

1. Identify 3 potential channel or partnership plays. Choose one. Resource it with a senior owner.
2. Formalise national-account management - dedicated person, different metrics from retail/ direct.
3. Explore licensing or private-label for products you over-produce or under-monetise.

"Most mature NZ manufacturers leave 20–40% of possible revenue on the table because they never build channels beyond direct sales. That revenue is already paid for - it just needs a route."

— Bernard Powell

Common trap Owners often mistake a fast yes for a good quote. The goal is not to win every job. The goal is to win the right work at the right margin, with a method someone else can repeat.

AREA 3 OF 7

Cash Flow From operating cash to capital strategy.

You're not running out of cash - you're running out of elegant ways to deploy it. Debt vs equity, dividend policy, share buy-backs, EBITDA optimisation for exit, tax structuring across the group. At this stage, financial strategy is valuation strategy.

\$M+ of optionality Capital structure choices at this scale create or destroy millions of dollars of optionality and exit value. This is where a great CFO and great tax counsel pay for themselves many times over.

The Fix:

1. Establish a formal capital structure review - debt, equity, reserves, dividend policy - annually.
2. Get a proper tax structuring review. Group, trusts, shareholding, IP ownership. All of it.
3. Treat every P&L decision as a valuation decision. EBITDA margin x exit multiplier = dollars on the table.

"At \$10M+, the gap between a median CFO and a great CFO isn't salary - it's a 1–2× turn on your exit multiplier."

— Bernard Powell

At this stage Cash flow discipline is less about finance jargon and more about facing reality weekly. A simple forecast reviewed every Friday beats a sophisticated spreadsheet you avoid opening.

AREA 4 OF 7

People Executive team works. Next: board and governance.

The executive team works. But there's no outside challenge, no independent judgement, no formal accountability. Bringing a real board - with independent directors and maybe a chair - changes the texture of every decision. It's also the single biggest driver of valuation multiplier among NZ privately-held businesses.

+1–3× multiplier Businesses with genuine governance (independent directors, formal board, clean reporting) consistently exit at 1–3× higher EBITDA multiples than founder- governed peers.

The Fix:

1. Appoint 2 independent directors with real industry or scaling experience. Pay them properly - this is not a favour.
2. Establish a formal governance rhythm: quarterly board meetings, monthly reporting packs, annual strategic plan.
3. Build an explicit succession plan for your own role. Even if you're 20 years away, the plan itself de-risks the business.

"A real board doesn't slow you down. It forces you to be clearer, faster, and more honest with yourself. That compounds over years."

— Bernard Powell

Bernard's note Most delegation fails because the standard was never clear enough to inspect. Give people the process, the expected result, and a review point. Then coach the gap instead of taking the job back.

AREA 5 OF 7

Systems Systems are sellable. Next: exit-ready.

Systems are sellable. But being sellable and being exit-ready are different things. Exit-ready means every fact a buyer cares about is already documented - the data room, contracts, customer concentration, IP, employment, tax - all ready to show on 7-day notice. Every year you delay this work is a year of unnecessary discount at sale.

10–20% valuation risk Deal-ready businesses sell at 10–20% higher valuations and close weeks faster than businesses that scramble to assemble diligence materials under pressure.

The Fix:

1. Assemble a live data room - financial, legal, HR, IP, customer. Keep it current, not just at sale-time.
2. Commission a "diligence stress test" - mock a buyer's questions today. Fix the weakest answers first.
3. Document the management system: how decisions get made, how leaders are developed, how the culture is sustained. Buyers pay for durable systems.

"The businesses that exit well aren't the ones with the best last-minute story. They're the ones that have been telling the same story - clean and documented - for years."

— Bernard Powell

Common trap If a process cannot survive your day off, it is not yet a system. Document the trigger, the steps, and what "done right" looks like. Then test whether someone else can run it without chasing you.

AREA 6 OF 7

Marketing Market leader. Next: category definer.

You're recognised as a leader in your category. The next step is category definition - owning the conversation about where the industry is going, what best practice looks like, what standards should be. That positioning creates pricing power, recruiting advantage, and a strategic moat that money can't easily buy.

The category premium Category-defining brands command pricing premiums of 15–30% and recruit the best talent cheaper. The compounding effect on margin is substantial across a decade.

The Fix - 5 Conversations This Week:

1. Publish a definitive industry report, annual benchmark, or standards document. Own the data in your category.
2. Take public positions on the future of your industry. The strongest category brands are led by opinionated founders, not quiet ones.
3. Build IP - patents, trademarks, proprietary methodologies. They show up in the valuation line-by-line.

"Category definition isn't marketing. It's strategy, done in public. The founders who do it create moats that outlast them."

— Bernard Powell

At this stage Referrals work best when you ask right after a win, not when things go quiet. One simple referral question used every month is stronger than a grand marketing plan nobody owns.

AREA 7 OF 7

Your Role Architect of the next era.

Your role is no longer operator, or even strategist. It's architect. You're designing what the business becomes over the next 10 years - the organisation, the leadership, the governance, the eventual transition out. This stage can last a decade. It can also end tomorrow if you're deliberate. Either way, the decisions only matter if they're made on purpose.

Your last decade The decisions you make in this stage frame the next 10–20 years of the business and your own life. The cost of drift here is enormous. The return on clarity is even bigger.

The Fix:

1. Write a 10-year vision for the business - concrete enough that successors can execute against it.
2. Choose your exit shape deliberately: sale, succession, ESOP, family transfer. Each requires different preparation.
3. Invest in yourself: peer groups, personal development, new interests. The strongest owners at this stage stay sharp because they keep growing themselves.

"The best owners I've seen at this scale stopped asking 'how do I keep growing revenue?' and started asking 'what do I want the next 10 years of my life to look like?' The second question is the one the business needs them to answer."

— Bernard Powell

Bernard's note Your highest-value work is choosing priorities, removing blockers, and making better decisions earlier. Every recurring task you keep by habit steals time from the part only the owner can do.

HOW YOU GRADUATE

The Stage 5 Standard The standard at this stage is long-cycle. 12–36 months of deliberate work, not 90 days of sprint.

• Real board in place - at least 2 independent directors, quarterly cadence • Capital structure and tax review completed annually • Deal-ready data room kept current year-round • Documented succession plan for owner and top 3 executive roles • 10-year vision written and shared with leadership team • Exit shape chosen deliberately - even if the exit is years away

This is no longer about the next 90 days. It's about what you want the business to mean in 10 years - and being deliberate enough, early enough, that the decision is yours rather than circumstance's.

Quick check before you move on • One number you will review every week • One task someone else now owns • One process the team can run without asking you

YOUR90 - DAY PLAN

The 10 Actions That Start the Next Era

These aren't the 90 days that will change the business - they're the 90 days that start you thinking at the right altitude.

WEEK 1–2 WEEK 3–4

1. Commission a proper valuation -
 1. Begin assembling the exit-ready don't guess. Understand the multiplier data room - even if exit is years away. and what moves it.
 2. Document a clear succession plan
 2. Interview 3 candidates for for your own role. independent director roles. Pick
 3. Kick off the 10-year vision people who will challenge you, not document. Start with: what should flatter you. this business be? What should it not
 3. Engage a tax / capital-structure be? specialist to review the full group.

MONTH 2 MONTH 3

1. Map your channel and partnership
 1. Review your calendar honestly. What opportunities. Pick one to pilot. % is strategy, what % is operations, what % is noise?
 2. Publish the first piece of category- defining content under your name.
 2. Book a peer group, conference, or coaching engagement for the next 12 months. You cannot outgrow what you're not exposed to.

90 days from now You'll have a valuation, a path to independent governance, the outline of a succession plan, and a clearer view of what the next decade looks like. That's the foundation of Stage 5.

Priority order Visibility first. Ownership second. Growth third. If you try to grow before the numbers and handoffs are real, you usually just scale the stress.

WHY BERNARD / PBA

You've Read the Roadmap. Now Don't Do It Alone.

Reading a roadmap is easy. Actually changing a factory is not. The owners who break through rarely do it alone: they borrow someone else's 30 years of pattern recognition, their own honest mirror, and their refusal to slip back into the comfort of being busy.

Bernard Powell built Premier Group NZ from scratch into a 200 tonne-per-day manufacturer, #1 NZ Best Workplace and AME Global Lean recognised. He lived every stage of your journey before coaching a single person.

500+ owners coached · 200 tonnes/day factory · #1 NZ Best Workplace · AME Global Lean · 141 five-star reviews

What actually changes when you work with Bernard

1. You stop guessing your numbers. The first session maps true cost per unit and your biggest profit leak. Fixing under-pricing alone often pays for the engagement.

2. You build the leverage you have been missing: systems, SOPs and delegated ownership. The boring work most coaches skip is what turns a factory from a trap into a business.

3. You get someone who has made the mistakes. Bernard has seen the ways NZ manufacturers break and the patterns that get them past \$5M+.

4. You do not get a generic playbook. Every session is grounded in your factory, your staff, your market and what you are dealing with this week.

Best fit: owners who want blunt feedback and fast implementation—not vague encouragement while keeping the same bottlenecks.

WHAT OWNERS SAY

Real NZ Owners. Real Results.

"Bernard is all go. Full of insights and immediate action. We have been blown away by just how quickly PBA implements and starts bringing positive change." — Adrian Day · NZ Manufacturer

"We have had great help from Bernard at PBA shifting mindset and getting stuff done that would otherwise never have happened." — Patrick Whiteman · NZ Business Owner

"Joining Premier Business Academy was one of the best things we have done in years. We joined because we wanted to improve the life our business gives us." — Joshua Prestidge · NZ Business Owner

"Bernard is the real deal business coach. Genuine, inspiring and full of energy and ideas. I am seeing a real upward trend in my sales results." — Tim Farland · NZ Business Owner

YOUR NEXT STEP

Stop guessing. Get a Growth Assessment Session. In 45 minutes, a top PBA advisor will help identify where your factory is, what is holding it back and the single most important thing to fix first.

[Book My Growth Assessment Session →](#)

500+ NZ manufacturers coached · 141 five-star reviews · Free, no obligation